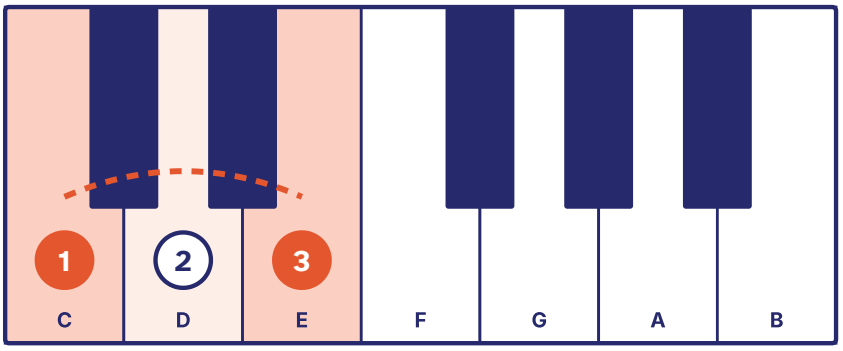
PART I · PITCH · 7

Counting intervals

How far apart are two notes? That distance is an **interval**. To give it a number, **count the notes**: the first note is 1, and you count every letter up to the second, both ends included.

THE SECRET

Count the notes, both ends included: C D E is 3 notes, a 3rd.

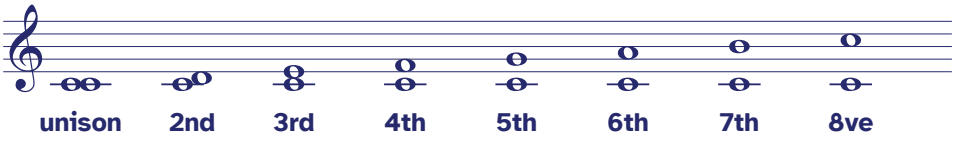


C to E: count the notes, 1 2 3: a 3rd

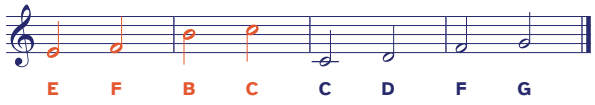
THE RULE

Count the notes for the number: start at 1 on the first note. C to E is C D E: 3 notes, a 3rd. Sharps and flats never change the number.

Interval numbers from C



The smallest steps: semitones and tones



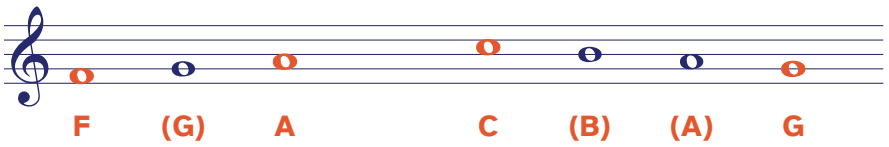
E–F and B–C: no black key between, a semitone. C–D and F–G: a black key between, a tone.

From any key to the **very next key**, black or white, is a **semitone**: the smallest step on the piano. Two semitones make a **tone**. On the white keys most steps are tones, but **E–F** and **B–C** have no black key between them: they are semitones.

PART I · PITCH · 7 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

How far apart are these notes?

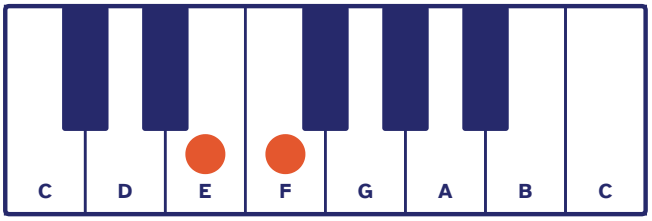


1. **Call the first note 1:** here F is 1.
2. **Count every letter** up to the second note.
3. **Going down works the same:** start at 1 on the top note and count down.

F G A is 3 notes: a **3rd**. C B A G is 4 notes: a **4th**.

EXAMPLE 2

Tone or semitone?

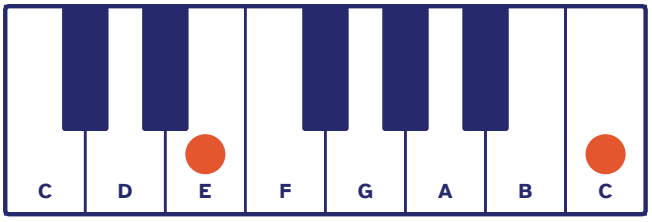


1. **Look between the red keys:** is there a black key?
2. **No black key** means they are next-door keys.
3. **Now try C and D**: is there a black key between?

E–F is a **semitone** (next door). C–D has C♯ between: a **tone**.

EXAMPLE 3

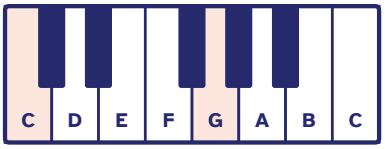
Name an interval on the keyboard



1. **Find both red keys:** E, and the C above it.
2. **Count the notes** from E: E is 1 …
3. **Stop on the C.** What number is it?

E F G A B C is 6 notes: a **6th**.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



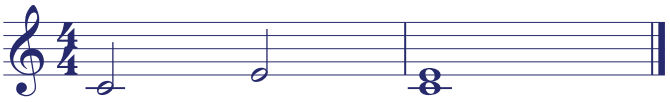
Thumb on C, finger 5 on G.

Your hand is a ruler: thumb to little finger on white keys is a 5th. Play it, then thumb to finger 3: a 3rd.

PART I · PITCH · 7 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

Melodic or harmonic?



1 **The first bar:** C, then E, one after the other.

2 **The second bar:** C and E at the same time.

3 **Count the notes** in each.

Both are a **3rd**: **melodic** when played one after the other, **harmonic** when played together.

GAME

Count the notes
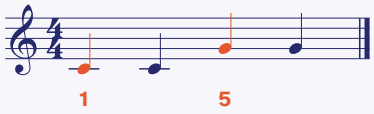
1	2	3	4
C up to G	D up to F	E up to the next E	G up to A

Count every note, both ends included. What is each interval called?

Answer: 1 a 5th (C D E F G) · 2 a 3rd · 3 an octave (8) · 4 a 2nd.

YOU KNOW THIS

Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star



The leap from the first “twinkle” to the second is C up to G: C D E F G, **five notes, a 5th**.

Try it. Sing the first two notes of any song, then count the notes between them.

THINK OF IT Monday to Wednesday is three days, not two: you count the day you start on. Intervals count the same way.

TRAP

- × Counting only the gaps, not the notes: C to E is 3 notes, not 2 gaps.
- × Letting a sharp or flat change the number: C to G♯ is still a 5th.

SEE ALSO

Major, minor and perfect p. 45 · Major scales p. 93

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Pitch 7 · Online: Intervals · Tones & Semitones